

THE DIVIDED SABBATH

REMARKS

CONCERNING

THE CRYSTAL PALACE

NOW ERECTING AT SYDENHAM.

"Do ye thus requite the Lord!"

DEUTERONOMY XXXII. 6.

BY THE REV. WILLIAM JOWETT, M.A.

INCUMBENT OF ST. JOHN'S CHURCH, CLAPHAM RISE,

AND LATE FELLOW OF ST. JOHN'S COLLEGE, CAMBRIDGE.

LONDON :

SEESEYS, FLEET STREET, AND HANOVER STREET,
HANOVER SQUARE.

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1852.

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THE DIVIDED SABBATH, &c. &c.

THE following Report, found in the *Times* of August 2d, 1852, appears to be, on one side at least, demi-official. It has given occasion to the Remarks contained in this pamphlet.

“We are happy to be able to state, that so far as the Government are concerned, no impediment will be thrown in the way, and that there is now no fear of the people’s losing their palace on the day on which they can best avail themselves of its many means of elevation and refinement. When the Directors of the Crystal Palace Company applied some few weeks since to Lord Derby for a Charter, they communicated to his Lordship the terms upon which they proposed to open the building and grounds on Sundays. They were of opinion, that until after one o’clock no trains should run from London, and the Crystal Palace itself should be strictly closed. After that hour they proposed to throw open the Park and the Winter-Garden, but not to exhibit those departments of the building, which will partake exclusively of a manufacturing and commercial character, the intention being to devote a certain portion of the space to specimens of manufactures, &c., which the public will be invited, upon certain conditions, to display. In the third place, the Directors undertook that on Sunday no spirituous liquors should be sold in their grounds. On Monday last Lord Derby requested an interview with the Directors, who, with Sir J. Paxton, waited upon the Premier and the Home Secretary in Downing Street. At this meeting his Lordship acquiesced in the stipulations proffered by the Crystal Palace Company, suggested a few trifling variations, and promised to grant the required Charter.”

An article in the *Times*, four days later, Aug. 6th, gives a full account of the ceremony of erecting the first column of the New Crystal Palace.

With every desire that the best interests of my Countrymen should be promoted, and with sincere respect for those who entertain a similar wish, I have felt it my duty as an Englishman, and still more as a Clergyman, to submit the following considerations to my Queen and my Country.

The Crystal Palace now erecting at Sydenham is designed to be the most splendid display of national greatness in the earth. No objection can exist to its grandeur, its beauty, the marvellous exotics to be exhibited in it, or to the display of ingenious manufactures. Some things it is intended to expose, which may prove decidedly objectionable: I refer to the sculpture-department. But I will not enter into details. The one great evil characterising the plan, is this—That it is designed to open the building to visitors during one half of the Lord's Day.

Observe—the people of London and its suburbs, that is, four millions, are invited to mutilate the Sabbath, by a plan which allows the first half to be given to God's worship, but allures them to spend the second half in worldly amusement. The favourers of the scheme virtually say—"Resort to the House of God in the morning, and to the Temple of Pleasure the rest of the day." This is a scheme far more artful, than if the enemy of mankind had said, "Give *the whole day* to me:" that would have shocked us at once: but—"Let half be given to God, and the second half to Pleasure"—this is plausible: and it is therefore so much the more dangerous.

I have said, four millions are thus invited. But consider the Counties involved in this invitation—the many watering-places in those counties, which have Excursion-trains in connection with London the whole of Sunday—the near neighbourhood of France and other Continental countries—the habits of those countries in making Sunday an open day for every kind of diversion. Taking all these points into consideration, there is something more to be contemplated, than the mere erection of a Crystal Palace.

Let us reflect how the plan will work. I have used a decent term, "Pleasure." And the favourers of the scheme may adopt terms yet more

reputable: inviting people to the study of Nature, in all the wonderful productions of native and foreign plants, leading them “from Nature up to Nature’s God.” This sounds well: but after all, the thing is, not what an elegant writer may describe it, but what the Million will make it. A poet, or an artist, may disguise a subject in a thousand ways: but this Temple of Pleasure will infallibly become, in the hands of the Million, a Focus of Dissipation.

Analyse a little this divided Sabbath, this Lord’s Day divided into two halves: not indeed perfectly equal halves; for the nominal date of recreation commences precisely one hour after mid-day: then the rush of railway carriages from the London terminus is to commence, Divine Service having at most Churches in and about London ended at one o’clock. Then, and in the hours following, the twenty, or the fifty thousand men, women and children, are to be set in motion. They will find no intoxicating drinks sold on the premises of the Crystal Palace! But will not the surrounding localities offer them, under the name of refreshments, whatever they please?

Look to the first part of the day. Does any man suppose that one half of these many thousands will have been worshipping God in the family and in the Church? Is it in the least degree likely? Does a single favourer of the scheme imagine it probable? I think not.

But then it will be pleaded, that the scheme is purposely so arranged, that people *might*, if they wished, go to Church with their families in the forenoon. I have even heard it gravely said, “The people *need not* break the Sabbath: they *may* go to Church in the morning; and if they do not, it is their own fault.” To this argument silence might be the best reply. And I hope truly, that the *Conscience of the Nation* will repudiate such sophistry.

I speak of Conscience: and I remember that the conscience of a Child is as much honoured and protected by God, as the conscience of any other individual. *Take heed that ye offend not one of these little ones.* Better for a man to have a millstone hanged about his neck, and he be cast into the sea, than that the moral sense of a young person be perverted. Suppose, now, a father or mother to take some of their children to Church, and hear the Commandments read: then imagine an ingenuous boy or girl, on the way to the Crystal Palace, saying, “The Minister read the words, *Remember that*

thou keep holy the Sabbath-day;” and they ask father or mother to reconcile the words of the command, and their excursion of amusement: the parents hush up the matter, by saying, “Children must not be particular; it is enough to keep holy *half the Sabbath Day*, and spend the rest of it pleasantly.” What a comment would this be!

This then is the sin, the one sin, at which I take aim. I do not pursue this part of the subject, by showing what multitudes of Railway servants, Publicans, Policemen, and others, will inevitably be absorbed during the entire Sabbath for miles and miles around, by this scheme. Here is the one crime, a divided Sabbath: here is the focus and centre of it, the Crystal Palace at Sydenham!—If any do not see the evil, or are determined to blink it, it will not be difficult to draw up a Sketch (not an exaggerated Sketch, but a very simple one, and so much the more convincing:) taking into view—1. London and its suburbs: 2. The circumjacent Counties: 3. The infection of the Continental Sabbath: 4. The state of the families of the industrial classes during the six week-days: and, 5. Their probable condition from Saturday Evening to Monday Evening, *forty-eight hours*, resulting from this scheme of a Divided Sabbath. But I hope that no such Tract will ever have to be written.

The projected *Aggression of Pleasure* in 1853 is to me a greater object of dread, than the *Aggression of Popery* in 1850: because it falls in with the taste of the vast majority of mankind. The danger of Popery I do not underestimate. It is a scheme adapted to fall in with the Formalism and Self-Righteousness of Man’s heart. There was also treachery in the camp of the Church of England, at the time when Popery took aim at the Royal Supremacy, and asserted its claim to be Lord of the consciences of all mankind: England, of course, included. But England repelled that aggression. The *Aggression of Pleasure* is more subtle, more extensive, more congenial. It is a subject, therefore, on which I must expatiate with the honest and affectionate freedom of a Clergyman.

Let me then observe, first, that it is a very difficult task *To move great masses of people in a right direction*. In a wrong direction, it is not so difficult. To rouse them to revolution, and then screw them down by

despotism, has been the work of a short time, in some neighbouring countries. But to draw them back from an evil purpose, and lead them into a right channel of feeling and action, is a hard work:—a consideration this, which makes it the more imperative to check at once this flagrant scheme of Sabbath-breaking before it begins. Once broken out, what human hand can turn back the torrent?

But is it not equally difficult *Rightly to move the heart even of one individual?* We speak of “The Million:” but that million is composed of units. To lead any one individual, be he rich or poor, to feel the value of his own soul, is a work worthy the labours and sacrifices of a whole life. To move that one heart, however, is not man’s work. *With man this is impossible: but with God all things are possible.*

Hence appears the importance of the *Prayer of faith*. Christ is the Strong One, stronger than Satan, in whose name prayer is to be offered to the Father: and in answer to believing prayer, the Holy Spirit is poured forth, on individuals, on Churches, on Nations, on the whole World. Who can overpower the Almighty Spirit, when it pleases Him to work? Without his influence, nothing, even under the most favourable circumstances, can be effected: with His influence, every good work, under most unfavourable circumstances, may and will be effected. *Not by power, not by might, but by my Spirit, saith the Lord of Hosts. Who art thou, O great mountain! before Zerubbabel, thou shalt become a plain.* By the power of the Spirit, every difficulty presented by the Million shall vanish. The heart of the Million shall be bowed, as the heart of one man. This will be in answer to prayer; whether secret prayer; or both secret and social prayer.

Another consideration deeply affecting to my mind, is this. Among the various means for the promotion and preservation of a nation’s welfare, there is not one of higher importance than the exercise of *A faithful Gospel-Ministry*. I am, on principle, a Clergyman of the Church of England: but I honour Ministers of every Communion, who with simplicity and godly sincerity preach Christ. In the present eventful crisis, we need the aid of all. Here is no question of Church and Dissent: the question is, whether or not Popery and Pleasure shall over-run the land—whether we shall uphold the Law of God, and Christ’s Gospel; or violate both.

There is a great Duty now lying before us: namely—*To make the Lord's Day profitable and interesting to the People*. By the Crystal Palace scheme the People are invited to Pleasure: at least for the second half of the day. The favourers of this scheme expressly undertake to teach the People “to amuse themselves:” and Sunday, from one o'clock till night-fall, is selected for the purpose of promoting this object among the working classes. As Ministers of Christ, then, are we not now brought to the test? “Will we endeavour to make the Lord's Day—the whole of it—interesting and useful to the Million? How likewise may we put the people into the way of making this day interesting to themselves?”

I feel the difficulties of this part of the subject: nor can I remove them by proposing so many more Sermons, Services, Sabbath-Schools, &c., although works of such kind would naturally form a part of any plan of extending usefulness. But I feel, and long have felt that there is one great, vital measure; which, if God should bless us in the universal promotion of that measure, will diffuse spiritual health and happiness through all classes of society.

To render the Lord's Day interesting, Religion itself must become interesting to a People. Every-day Religion is the only thing that can make a Sunday-Religion profitable and interesting. The one topic of pre-eminent importance in this point of view is—*The General introduction of Family Prayer*. Domestic Worship is among the greatest of earthly blessings, both to the Rich and to the Poor. We say in England, “Every man's house is his Castle.” For all domestic purposes, let every man's house be also his Church! In setting up this standard, the Ministers of Christ have a noble task before them. Our public Congregations on the Lord's Day will not be diminished by the multiplication of these Domestic Sanctuaries during the week: these, on the contrary, will render our every-day Religion interesting, and thus make also the Sabbath a delight. They will fill our Churches, and thin the throng of Sabbath-breakers, please God, to nothing!

As to the notion that this violation of the Sabbath will give rest and mental refinement to the people, it is an utter delusion. Last year I was conversing about the Excursion-trains with an aged relative, who has since been removed to the eternal world. When under twenty years of age he was for a while engaged in mercantile business, in one of the most active and opulent

of our manufacturing towns: but from pure love to the work of the Ministry he relinquished very flattering worldly prospects, and for more than forty years was a burning and a shining light in the parish and in the county where he laboured. Referring to his early days, and viewing with alarm the threatening abuses of the Railways, he remarked to me—"They quite mistake the idea of Sunday-rest, who suppose that it consists in pleasure-taking. When I was engaged in business, early and late on all the week-days—very often so tired out that I scarcely knew what to do with myself—Sunday was the greatest possible refreshment to me. The mere act of ceasing from work, together with reading my Bible and going to Church, was rest. But then," he added, "this implies a change of heart; a different taste from what the world has."

I have thus written from the fulness of my heart, and from the deepest convictions of my judgment, believing that a crisis of great danger to our beloved country is closely impending. If a Royal Charter has been promised, specifically authorising the opening of the Crystal Palace on any part of Sunday, then the Poor are in the fair way to be robbed of their real Rest, by the substitution of an imaginary recreation, so arranged that it cannot be enjoyed without sin. If the Royal sanction were actually given, I would yet look to "The Million," Englishmen as they are, and Bible-men, to reject the proffered amusement. How may the threatened evil be averted? Whether deliverance shall be sent from some very humble quarter; or whether it shall be the hand of a Queen, more wary than Darius, that shall refuse to sign the writing and the decree, God alone knoweth! My earnest hope and prayer, is, that the rumour of such a Charter may die away to nothing. As Englishmen, may we be roused from our dreams of amusement to a higher standard of duty! May History never have to record, that in the nineteenth century it was sought to erect—and in Britain, too—a People's happiness on the basis of God's broken law!

THE END.

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE DIVIDED
SABBATH ***

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